I Stopped Writing Poetry

By Bernard Welt

I stopped writing poetry
when the internet replaced the telephone
(since now that *everyone* has a phone,
and takes it *everywhere*, it's obvious
the telephone is *over*). Ted Berrigan I thought
destroyed the sonnet by inviting the beloved
to just pick up the phone and call him
sometime-- thus no more need to plead
and seduce through verse--

INTRODUCTION

Through the emergence of numerous poetry classes and more forgiving professors, we now have an influx of really bad poetry. Poetic style, the people who write it, is diverse, as poet Sharon Creech once wrote, "any words can be a poem; you've just gotta make short lines..." The following poetic selection seeks to examine the parallels between the state of poetry today and the diversity of life. I stopped writing poetry... by Bernard Welt.

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I stopped writing poetry
When I was just starting to get good at it. First,
I got good at rhyme, so I cast it away.
Then I got good at line and stanza construction--
So good I hardly needed to *say* anything at all.
My meanings emerged
in the spaces between.
So I got rid of that, too. Metaphor, metonymy,
Allusive echoes of my betters -- well, frankly,
I was a whiz at that stuff pretty early on.
So I emptied out the file drawers
Of rhetorical strategy, musical form,
Continuity or criticism of tradition,
And I just wrote. Finally I found
I was writing... *prose*, like everyone else.
But it was prose with a difference: prose with a rich,
Totally hidden other life lying behind it, unglimpsed
(I think) by the reader. Not like a prostitute
Who reforms and becomes a nun. I've seen
That movie. More like a nun who becomes a prostitute.

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I stopped writing poetry but I still love the stanza.
All that other cool stuff--
tropes, the caesura, enjambment-- I can live without.
But the *stanza*-- wow.

I stopped writing poetry
after I went to my first MLA conference,
where they were attacking a way of reading
and understanding literature they called
"mainstream" and "dominant" that I'd never even
encountered. It was like what they meant by "book"
was totally different from what I meant by "book"--
as different as "washing machine" and "golf ball."

I stopped writing poetry when people began writing
scholarly articles explaining how to read Frank
O'Hara's
Lunch Poems and it never occured to them to mention
that you should read them during lunch.

I stopped writing poetry

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when everyone else did-- in the early 90s, when
television
became more interesting than culture.

I stopped
writing poetry when it became popular. I realize
Robert Frost read at Kennedy's inauguration but now
Ethan Hawke is telling _Vanity Fair_ that he keeps
your book by his bed, and poetry as adjunct
to commercial culture and the veneration of celebrity
is so much more deliciously embarrassing for everyone
than even poetry in the service of the state.

I stopped writing poetry
because I promised to. I read something
in which I encouraged everyone
to give up writing-- as I engaged to-- and it went
over
real big. Afterwards any time I ran into any of the
poetry crowd they'd always ask me if I was still
not writing. I understood it was a performance piece

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and so did they but I keep getting this gnawing
feeling
I was abandoning a prinicple by continuing to write.
It was entirely superstition, like actually feeling
sick
when you call in sick, but I suppose I have been a
victim
of the terrible conviction that you must mean what you
say.
I stopped writing poetry
when I had dedicated poems to everyone I knew, at
least everyone I wanted to impress.
I promise to start writing poetry again as soon as I
meet some new people.
Interesting people, anyway.
Interesting people I can't just come out and *say*
things to, anyway.

I stopped writing poetry
at 16 (seriously), then again at about 20 but only for
six months, once again at 27, then at 32, 35, 40, and

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42. I'll keep you posted.

I stopped writing poetry
when I received the praise of people I admired.
It's a terrible thing to receive exactly the attention
you want
when you are unprepared to admit you might deserve it.
Of the many ways in which poets are always going on
about how poetry not only receives inspiration from
love
but imitates it in form and feeling, this just may be
the worst.

I stopped writing poetry--
well, basically, because I'm white. I don't
like being white, it isn't a choice I'd make freely,
and to get argumentative I don't think it's entirely
fair
that I have to be white right now when it's so 10
minutes ago
when if I'd been born fifteen years earlier most

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racists
would have considered me anything but, what with
the whole Jew-as-vermin thing, but OK, OK, I concede
the point, I'm culturally white, or whatever,

and in case you haven't noticed, this just isn't
white people's moment, poetry-wise. Don't even
get me *started* on the great tradition and that
stuff,
I mean, just look at rap-- poetry that communicates
exquisitely within its chosen boundaries of class
and common interest, and hardly at all outside it,
except for those to whom it stands as aspiration to
cool.
Just like Shakespeare and Donne. What have white
people
contributed to culture recently? *Postmodernism*?
Please.
My own revelation came when I realized
"Little Red Corvette" meant more to me than any poem
published since the early 1970s. On the not-very

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mean streets where I learned versification, poetry
wasn't a mode of expression spontaneously developed
from living people's lived experience, it was a
regime.
Well, that's over now. Get over it.

I stopped writing poetry
when I got married-- I mean settled down--
since the laws of the state of Maryland do not allow
me
to marry the love of my life-- though I'm not here
to whine about it-- and maybe marriage would ruin me
as it seems to have ruined others-- but one thing I
know--
it is certainly nice to have someone to blame
for taking it easy and resisting inspiration when it
inconveniently
insists on arising occasionally no matter what you do

I stopped writing poetry
When my friends started dying. Some of my friends

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Wrote beautifully about the conditions of their
illness,
And insightfully about mortality and their own
impending
Death. Some wrote angrily about their invisibility
And created a literature of testimony in which we
learn
What it was like to walk in the streets of American
cities
As a ghost. Some wrote poems to memorialize their
lovers.
Or to embarrass right-wing senators or arts funding
agencies.
But I counted 67 people I knew and was fond of
Who've died of "AIDS-related illness," and not once
Have I genuinely felt I could respond to their
suffering or death
In poetry. Is it poetry? Is it me? The era? I am
willing to believe
That if Milton and Shelley and Tennyson could do it,
It can still mean something. Why should I think their

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ages
Made death any more manageable a subject than mine?
But whenever I sat down to try, I stopped in despair.
Whatever the political advantages of slogans
Of the time, it wasn't the right words I looked for
But some way to make silence heard in lines
Of verse, and I never found it.

I stopped writing poetry when it was eclipsed by
criticism
for purely sociological and economic reasons.
I stopped writing poetry when taking it seriously
started seeming more likely to indicate
intellectual complacency than intellectual liveliness.
I stopped writing poetry when it got boring.

I stopped writing poetry
but as satisfying as it has been to turn my back on it
as on a distant homeland fallen under the spell of a
fascist party
still a breeze reaches me from time to time fragrant

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of verse

and suddenly I am as nostalgic as an exiled Russian

grand duke waiting on tables in Paris in a screwball

comedy

sometimes I wonder would it really be so terrible

if I wrote just one more line

Now even that

Sounds like a device to me, like special pleading.

Let someone else do it.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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